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SMACT v4: Enhanced Screening and Prediction Tools for Computational Materials Design

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Summary

SMACT (Semiconducting Materials by Analogy and Chemical Theory) is a Python library for the high-throughput screening and discovery of inorganic materials. The name reflects foundational analogy-based approaches to semiconductor prediction (Goodman, 1958; Pamplin, 1964). Originally published as a JOSS paper in 2019 (Davies et al., 2019), the package provided chemical filters based on charge neutrality, electronegativity, and elemental data to rapidly identify chemically plausible compositions (Davies et al., 2016). Since then, SMACT has undergone substantial development from v2.1 through v4.0. The library now includes modules for crystal structure prediction via data-mined ionic substitution (Hautier et al., 2011), dopant prediction, composition-to-property prediction using deep learning models (Goodall & Lee, 2020), and tools for mapping inorganic crystal chemical space (Park, Onwuli, et al., 2025). These additions transform SMACT from a compositional screening tool into a comprehensive platform for computational materials design.

Statement of Need

The search space for new inorganic materials is immense—exceeding 4×10^{12} quaternary element combinations (Davies et al., 2016)—and continues to grow as multi-component systems attract interest. Researchers need tools that can rapidly filter this space using established chemical principles before committing to expensive first-principles calculations or synthesis. The original SMACT addressed this need through charge neutrality and electronegativity screening. However, the field has since advanced: researchers now require not only compositional screening but also structure prediction, property estimation, and integration with modern machine learning workflows.

SMACT v4 meets these needs by providing a unified Python library where a researcher can (i) enumerate and filter compositions, (ii) predict likely crystal structures from data-mined substitution probabilities, (iii) estimate material properties directly from stoichiometry without requiring structural information, and (iv) identify candidate dopants for known host materials. The library is designed for desktop-scale computation, with data caching and multiprocessing support that enables screening of millions of compositions in minutes.

State of the Field

Several established libraries serve the computational materials science community. `Pymatgen` (Ong et al., 2013) provides comprehensive tools for structure manipulation and thermodynamic analysis. The Atomic Simulation Environment (`ASE`) (Larsen et al., 2017) focuses on atomistic simulations. `Matminer` (Ward et al., 2018) specialises in featurisation and machine learning pipelines for materials data. These tools primarily operate on known structures or experimental data.

SMACT occupies a distinct niche: it works at the composition level, upstream of structure-based tools, to define which regions of chemical space merit further investigation. This top-down, composition-first approach complements structure-based workflows. The structure prediction and property prediction modules added since v2.0 provide natural bridges between SMACT's compositional screening and downstream structural analysis tools. The `ElementEmbeddings` integration (Antunes et al., 2022) further connects SMACT to modern representation learning approaches for materials informatics (Onwuli et al., 2024).

Software Design

SMACT v4 retains the `Element` and `Species` classes at its core, providing access to tabulated data for all elements in arbitrary oxidation states and coordination environments. The following major modules have been added since the original publication.

Structure prediction. Implements data-mined ionic substitution methods (Hautier et al., 2011) to predict likely crystal structures for new compositions by analogy with known parent structures, using substitution probabilities derived from statistical analysis of experimental databases.

Dopant prediction. Enables high-throughput identification of p-type and n-type dopants for a given host composition by combining oxidation state filters with ionic radius constraints and species embedding similarities.

Property prediction. Provides composition-to-property prediction using pre-trained ROOST models (Goodall & Lee, 2020), allowing users to predict band gaps directly from chemical formulae with uncertainty estimates.

Oxidation states and metallicity. Implements a probabilistic model for predicting the likelihood of metal species coexisting in compounds based on anion-dependent statistics (Davies et al., 2018), with updated default data (ICSD24). A metallicity scoring module distinguishes ionic compounds from intermetallic phases.

Crystal space utilities. Tools for systematically mapping inorganic composition space (Park, Onwuli, et al., 2025), including data acquisition, composition generation, and dimensionality-reduced visualisation of compositional embeddings.

Screening enhancements. The core screening functions now support mixed-valence compositions, switchable oxidation state datasets, and consensus-based filtering.

Research Impact

Park et al. (Park, Onwuli, et al., 2025) used SMACT's screening and crystal space tools to map the landscape of inorganic crystal chemistry. Onwuli et al. (Onwuli et al., 2024) employed SMACT's species representations for materials informatics, developing ionic embeddings that capture oxidation-state-dependent chemical behaviour. Park et al. (Park, Mastej, et al., 2025) used SMACT in a workflow for closing the synthesis gap in computational materials design. Nduma et al. (Nduma et al., 2025) integrated SMACT into the Crystalyse multi-tool agent for autonomous materials design.

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AI Usage Disclosure

Generative AI tools (Claude, Anthropic) were used to assist with code modernisation tasks during the v4.0.0 development cycle, including type annotation additions, test migration, and documentation formatting. All AI-generated code was reviewed and validated by the authors. The first draft of this manuscript was prepared with AI assistance and reviewed by all co-authors.

Author Contributions

KOM is the current maintainer. She contributed consensus-based oxidation state filtering for `smact_validity` and `smact_filter`, and led the v4.0.0 release including mixed-valence support, a deep code audit, full type annotations, security hardening, test migration to pytest with coverage raised to over 85%, and CI consolidation. AO was the primary developer from v2.2 to v3.1, contributing the dopant prediction module, oxidation states improvements, crystal space utilities, and extensive maintenance. AM designed and implemented the structure prediction subpackage and benchmarking framework. DWD is the original lead developer and contributed to CI infrastructure and code quality tooling. RN implemented the property prediction subpackage, metallicity module, and screening performance optimisations. KTB is an original author who continued contributing to the codebase. JL contributed the initial dopant prediction implementation and charge state comparison fixes. PD contributed to lattice parameter calculations. AMG contributed to code quality and structure. HP contributed the crystal space visualisation tools and element data corrections. REAG fixed a screening bug related to electronegativity handling. TL contributed to code reorganisation and utility refactoring. AW supervised the project and contributed to the codebase.

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